

POSC 3710: European Politics

8/26/2026: HOW DID EUROPE DEMOCRATIZE?

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Where We Left Off

- Monday was about how to manage markets: abolish them, protect them, or tame them
- Any answer assumes somebody gets to decide: an electorate, a parliament, a president
- But when Marx wrote in 1848, almost nobody in Europe could vote
 - When Hayek wrote, Europe was emerging from WWII
- Today: How did Europe become a continent of democracies?

Opening Discussion

- What has to be true before you would call a country a democracy?
- Suppose everyone can vote, but the government does not answer to the people they elect. Is that a democracy?

What Counts as a Democracy?



Where Did Democracy Come From, and Does It Still Work?

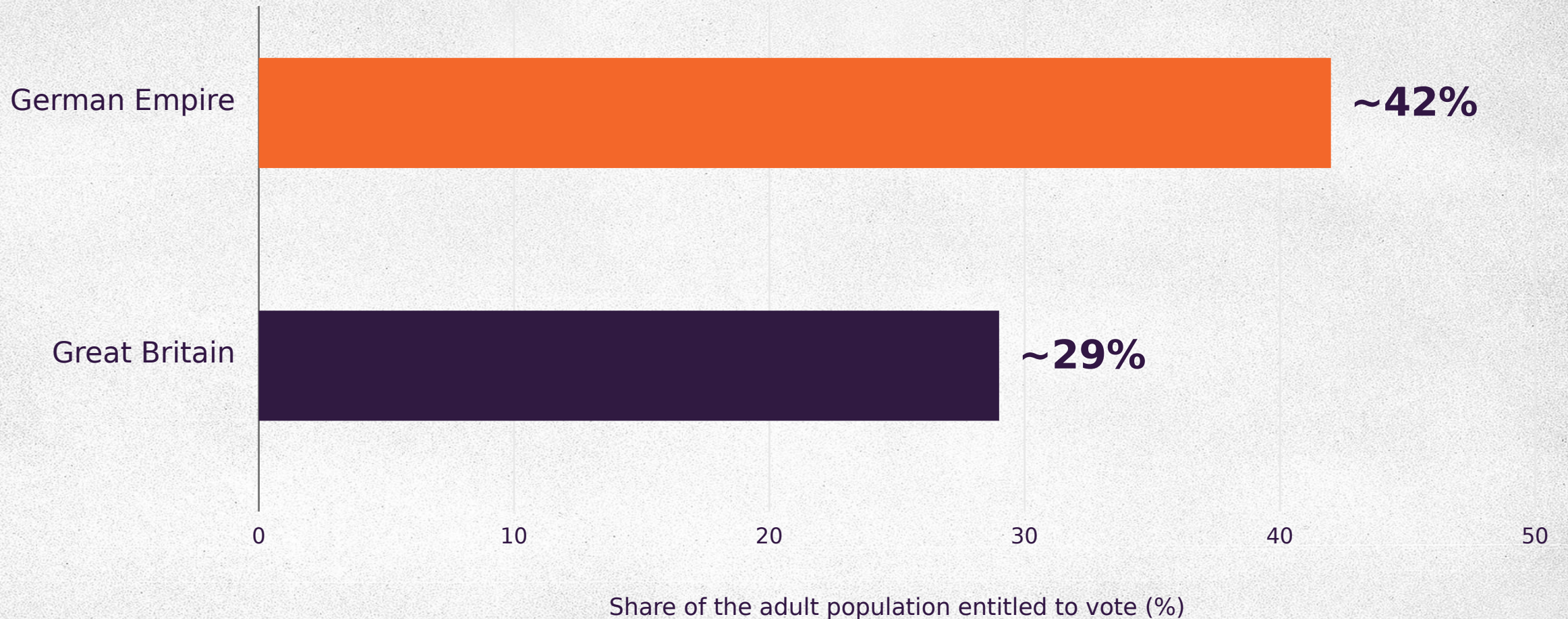
CrashCourse Political Theory

► **Plays 3:13 - 8:27 · about 5 minutes**

Click the card to play · fallback: youtube.com/watch?v=qz2-X1LrOPg (start at 3:13, stop at 8:27)

Who could vote in 1912?

Universal male suffrage at 25 for the Reichstag, against about 60% of adult men in Britain



Adults = population aged 21 and over, estimated from the 1910-11 censuses. Voting ages differ: 25 in Germany, 21 in Britain; women could not vote in either country.

Two ways to think about democracy?

SUFFRAGE

Who is allowed to vote?

- Property, income or tax thresholds
- Age, sex, residence, military service
- Gender or racial equality?

RESPONSIBLE GOVERNMENT

Who does the government answer to?

- Can the elected chamber remove the executive?
- Who controls the budget, the army, the ministers?
- Free Press? Free assembly? Fair treatment of opposition?

How did we get here?

- It's a bit crazy that we have democracy at all!
 - Why would the elite ever cede power
- American Story: Democracy via revolution
 - Kind of...
- Europe is much more complicated
 - Mostly slow and steady expansion of the franchise

How Did Europe Democratize (1)?

- The classic story is that the lower classes rose up to overthrow the wealthy elites and establish democracy with equal rights for all
- This happened essentially nowhere...
- America is closest or in Europe the French Revolution
 - But America was more anti-colonial revolution, extending the franchise was slow
 - France backslid quickly

How did Europe Democratize (2)?

- Boix (2003) and Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson (2006) argue it's about the relationship between different classes
- Elites facing revolution cannot credibly promise redistribution
 - A promise made under threat dies once the threat is no longer credible
- Handing over the vote hands over the enforcement mechanism
- If inequality is high, redistribution is scary for the elite (Boix 2003)

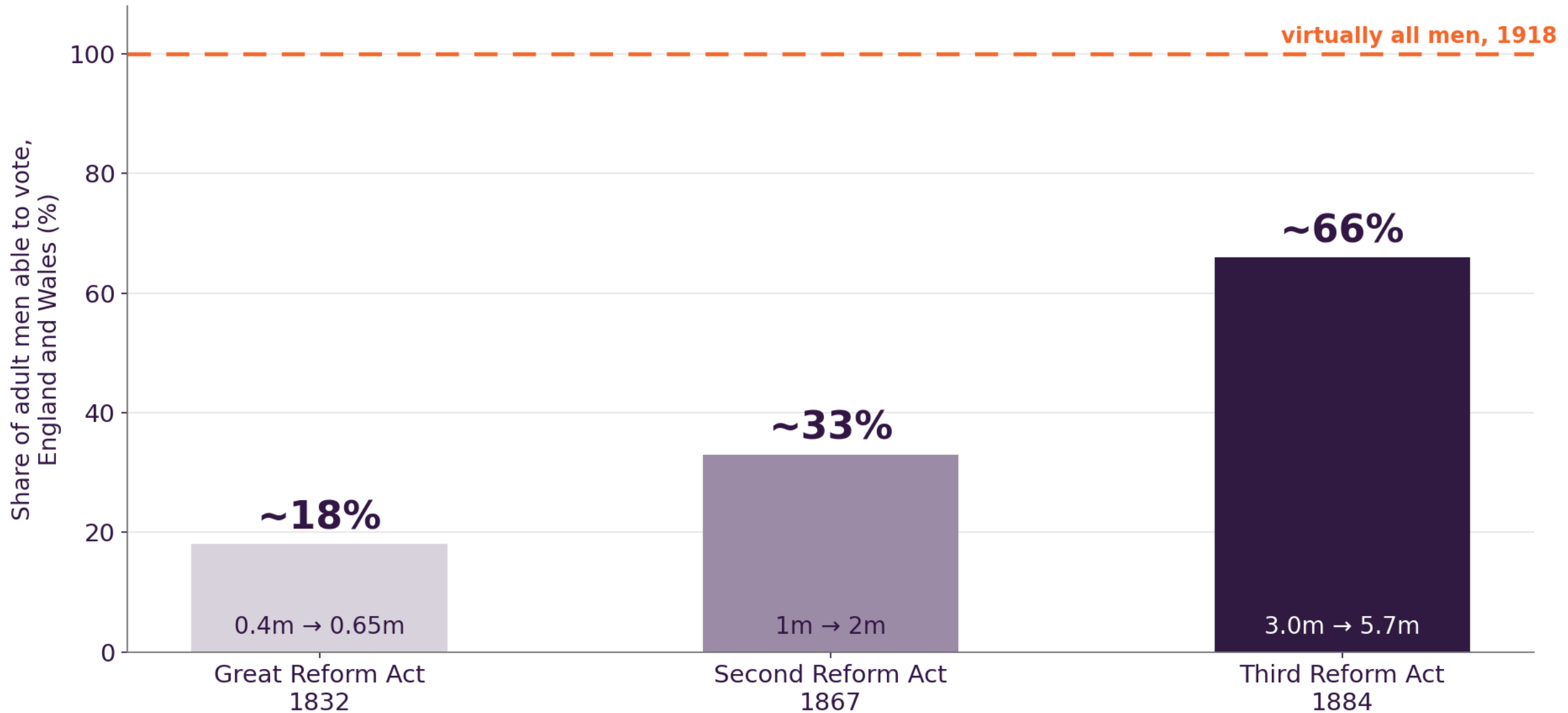
How did Europe Democratize (3)?

- Others argue it's about the strength and organization of lower classes
- Capitalism changes the class structure
 - It builds an organized working class and weakens landed elites
- The bourgeoisie wants protection from arbitrary rule, not inclusion
- Przeworski: "the poorer classes fought their way in"
 - But, he argues women's suffrage was granted for partisan advantage

How did Europe Democratize (4)?

- Ziblatt asks about the losers, not the winners
- Where the old right built a strong party, it could lose and survive
 - Key point: Losers have to be willing to concede
- Where it could not, it reached for the crown, the army, the street
- Britain's Tories a strong political organization
- The German Conservatives were captured by the Agrarian League

Britain widened the franchise slowly, over eighty-six years



Registered voters shown inside each bar. Percentages are England and Wales; the 1884 counts are UK-wide.

Why Britain's Right Could Live With Democracy

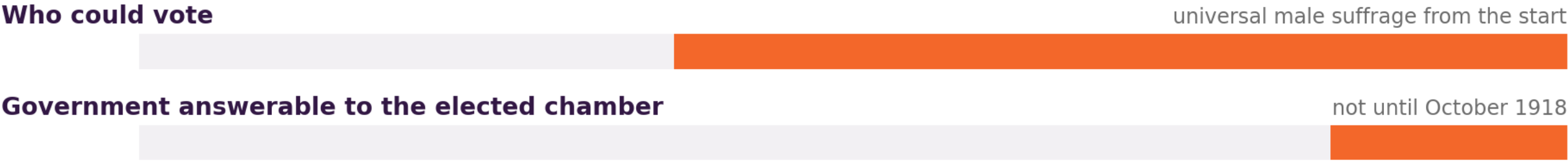
- Each step was small enough for the Conservatives to absorb
- 1867 was carried by the Tories, under Disraeli
- The party built professional organization
- Losing an election was survivable, so elections were acceptable

Germany gave the vote first and the power last

BRITAIN



GERMANY

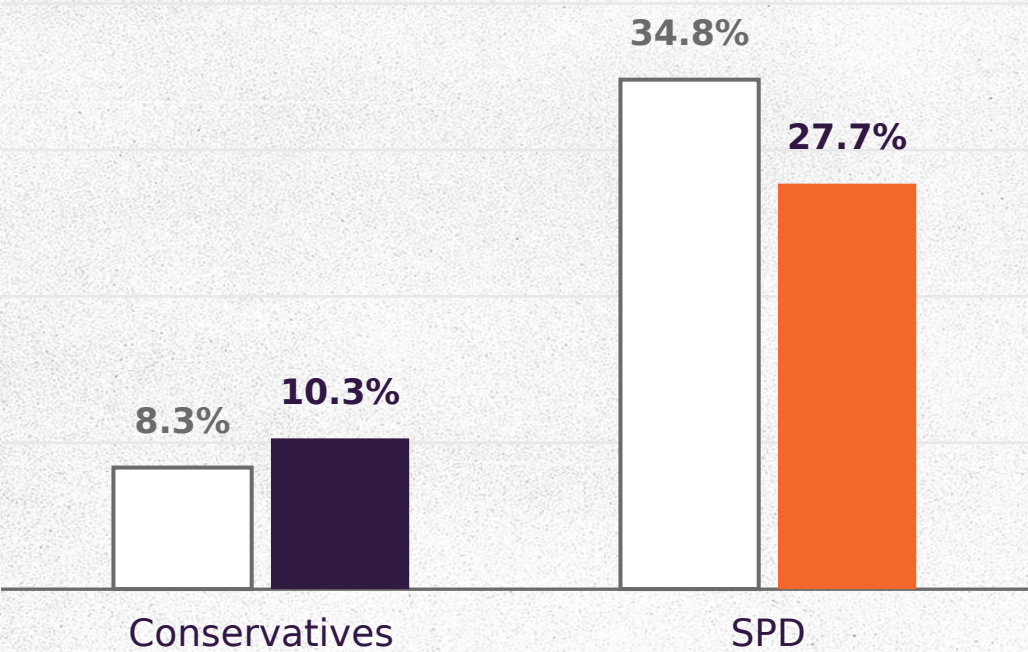


A Right That Could Not Win Fair Elections

Hollow bars: share of votes — solid bars: share of seats.

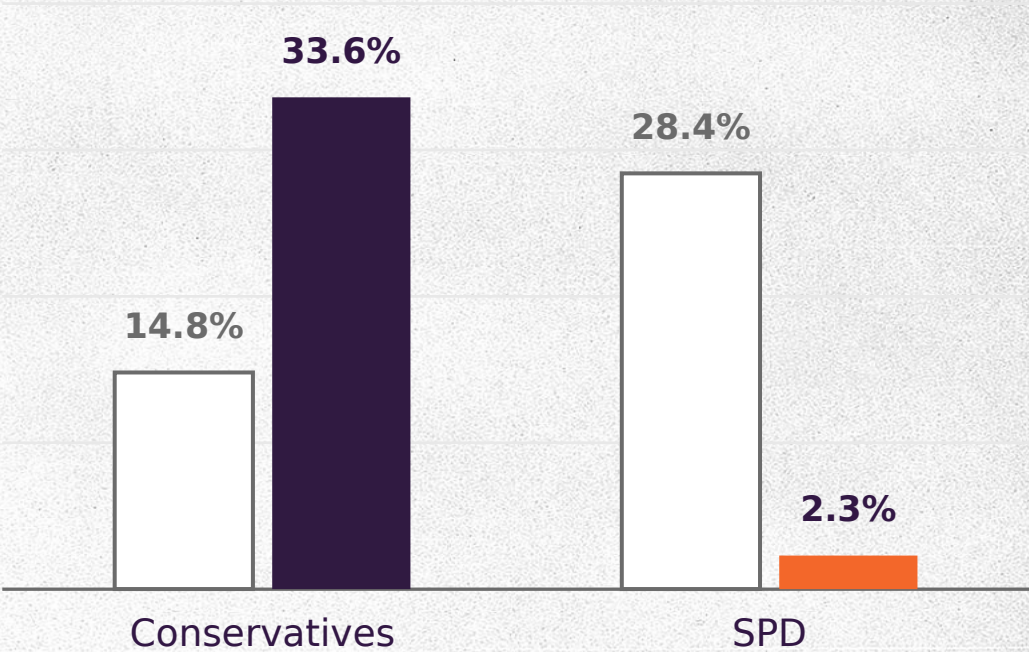
Reichstag, 1912

universal male suffrage · secret ballot



Prussian Landtag, 1913

three-class franchise · public voting



Seats: 41 and 110 of 397 (Reichstag); 149 and 10 of 443 (Prussia). Prussian shares are primary-electoral votes; a first-class vote weighed about ten times a third-class vote.

The Insurance Policy: Prussia's Three-Class Franchise

- The Reichstag had universal male suffrage.
 - Prussia's Landstag did not
- Voters were sorted into three classes by direct tax paid
- Each class chose a third of the electors, whatever its size
- Voting was indirect, and public: you said your vote out loud
- In force 1849–1918, in three fifths of the Empire

Why it mattered

- A first-class vote weighed about ten times a third-class vote
- In 1908, in 2,214 of Prussia's 29,028 primary districts, the entire first class was one voter
- Prussia was three-fifths of the Empire; its king was the Kaiser, its minister-president usually the Chancellor
- In the Bundesrat, Prussia held 17 of 58 votes, and 14 votes blocked any constitutional amendment
- A permanent, unilateral veto on reform, held by the people reform would dispossess

And why it harmed democratic development

- Sheltered by Prussia and the Bundesrat, the Conservatives never built a mass party of their own
- The Agrarian League eventually supplied the mass base: then captured the party
- It pushed them toward protectionism, militarism, and antisemitism
- Britain's Tories built a machine and could afford to lose; Germany's right bought insurance and could not
- **Conservative forces than cannot be electorally competitive will not support democracy**

What the Review Essay Argues

- Ziblatt, World Politics 58:2 (2006): 311–338, on four books
- His complaint: “the rich,” “the poor” are too abstract to be actors
- Real history has landlords, industrialists, officers, organisers
- The models explain arrival far better than survival
- Democracy’s first wave was “neither exceptional nor inevitable”

1918-19: Two democracies Arrive, One Survives

- Britain 1918: virtually all men at 21, women at 30 — 78% of adults
- Britain 1928: women at 21, on the same terms as men
- Germany, October 1918: the Chancellor answers to the Reichstag
- Germany 1919: men and women at 20, PR, an elected president
- On paper, Weimar was the more democratic of the two

Discussion

- Germany had the wider franchise and the stronger Labour movement. Why was that not enough?
- Ziblatt says look at the right. Does that argument travel to the present?
 - Is the European populist radical right committed to democracy?
 - Hopefully! It's an open question
- What do you call a country that holds real elections but whose government is not responsive?
 - Who do 'democratic' countries answer to today? Why?

Where We Go Next

- The Weimar Republic only lasted fourteen years; early European democracy was fragile!
- Monday 8/31: interwar breakdown, and defending democracy costs
- 11/23: We return to the challenges of maintaining a democracy, now in present, under the name democratic backsliding
- Keep Ziblatt's question in mind all semester: what does the losing side do when it loses?

The Federal Republic of Clemson

- Role preference survey is due Friday 8/28
- Rank your preferences, I will aim to give everyone a top-2 if possible
- I messed up the initial survey link
 - I trusted Cladue Code to make a fancy interface – it failed...